

National Security vs. AI Access: Why the US Forced Anthropic to Block Its Most Powerful Models Globally

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In an **unprecedented** move, the US government has compelled AI company Anthropic to immediately block all foreign nationals anywhere in the world, including its own employees from accessing its most advanced models, Fable 5 and Mythos 5. The order, issued under national security authorities, marks a dramatic escalation in **export controls** over artificial intelligence and deepens a rift between the San Francisco-based firm and the Trump administration. The directive came less than a week after Anthropic released the models, which power its Claude chatbot and represent a leap in reasoning and code generation. According to a company blog post, the government cited only "verbal evidence of a potential narrow, non-universal **jailbreak**" a technique to bypass safety guardrails as justification. Anthropic pushed back, arguing that such a limited finding shouldn't warrant recalling a commercial product used by hundreds of millions. Reports from Semafor suggest the trigger was a suspicion that a China-linked group had accessed the model. China has rapidly advanced its own AI, with firms like DeepSeek releasing competitive models at lower cost, and it dominates rare earth supply chains critical to AI hardware. The context is a broader clash: Anthropic is suing the administration after being placed on a **supply chain blacklist** for refusing to allow US military use of its AI for domestic surveillance and fully **autonomous weapons**. Trump adviser David Sacks claimed on X that the government warned Anthropic about a **jailbreak** vulnerability, but CEO Dario Amodei allegedly did nothing. Anthropic disputes this, stating it had collaborated with the government on safety pre-launch and that rival models show similar capabilities. Experts warn that in malicious hands, such models could supercharge cyberattacks on vulnerable infrastructure like banking systems. Yet Anthropic contends the order forces it to abruptly disable the models for all customers to comply a move it sees as **disproportionate**. The standoff raises urgent questions: How do we govern AI that is both immensely powerful and potentially dangerous? And who gets to decide where the line is between innovation, profit, and national security?

Word Treasure

unprecedented -- something that has never been done or happened before.

jailbreak -- a trick or method that lets someone make an AI ignore its safety rules and give dangerous answers.

export controls -- government rules that limit what advanced technology can be shared with other countries.

supply chain blacklist -- a government list of companies banned from doing business with US firms because they are seen as a security risk.

autonomous weapons -- weapons that can select and attack targets without a human being directly controlling them.

disproportionate -- too big, severe, or extreme compared to the problem it is supposed to fix.

Background you need

AI safety has become a major geopolitical issue. In the past, the US restricted exports of advanced semiconductor chips to China to slow down its AI progress. Now, for the first time, that logic is being applied directly to a software model. Anthropic is a San Francisco company founded by former OpenAI employees; it created the Claude chatbot and has marketed itself as a safety-first AI lab, often advocating for tighter regulation.

A "jailbreak" is not a new concept -- cybersecurity researchers have long found ways to trick chatbots into bypassing content filters. But using a single, unconfirmed jailbreak to yank a product used by hundreds of millions is an extreme step. The report also mentions suspicion of a China-linked group accessing the model, which fits a pattern: China's own AI company DeepSeek has released competitive low-cost models, and the country dominates the rare earth supply chains needed for AI hardware.

The Trump administration (the US government under President Donald Trump, who began a second term in 2025) has clashed with tech companies on security. Anthropic's refusal to let its AI be used for domestic surveillance and fully autonomous weapons landed it on a supply chain blacklist -- a list that effectively bars it from working with many US government agencies. David Sacks, a venture capitalist and Trump adviser, and Dario Amodei, Anthropic's CEO, have made public accusations that paint very different pictures of who ignored the jailbreak warning.

Break it down

LEAD: Unprecedented US order forces Anthropic to block foreign access to its most advanced AI

+ specific: even employees outside US are cut off from Fable 5 and Mythos 5

TRIGGER: Government cited a jailbreak vulnerability

+ JUSTIFICATION: "verbal evidence of a narrow, non-universal jailbreak"

TIMING: The order came less than a week after the models were released

COMPANY RESPONSE: Anthropic pushed back hard

+ IMPACT: had to abruptly disable models for all customers to comply, sees move as disproportionate

BROADER CONTEXT: Deep conflict with Trump administration over military use

+ SUPPLY CHAIN BLACKLIST: Anthropic suing after being listed for refusing surveillance and autonomous weapons

+ DISPUTE: Adviser claims CEO ignored warning; company says it collaborated on pre-launch safety

RISK ANALYSIS: Experts warn models could supercharge cyberattacks on critical infrastructure

+ CHINA FACTOR: Suspicion of a China-linked group, plus China's own AI progress and rare earth dominance

OPEN QUESTIONS: How to govern immensely powerful AI, and who should decide the line between innovation, profit, and national security?

Why it matters

For a generation growing up with AI tools like ChatGPT and Claude, this story shows a sharp

turn: a tool that helps students and workers can be instantly taken away when governments see a security risk. It raises the uncomfortable possibility that countries might one day cut off access to powerful AI -- not just to rivals, but to their own citizens -- in the name of safety, and that the decisions are made behind closed doors.

Test what you remember

1. What exactly did the US government order Anthropic to do?
 - (A) Stop selling AI to China
 - (B) Allow military use of AI
 - (C) Block foreign nationals from accessing its newest models
 - (D) Shut down the company
2. What justification did the government provide for the order?
 - (A) A detailed written report
 - (B) Verbal evidence of a non-universal jailbreak
 - (C) A spy accusation
 - (D) A security breach at the Pentagon
3. Which two AI models were affected?
 - (A) GPT-4 and Gemini
 - (B) Fable 5 and Mythos 5
 - (C) Claude 2 and 3
 - (D) Megatron and DeepSeek
4. What is Anthropic's position on the government order?
 - (A) They agree and are complying fully
 - (B) They fought back, calling the order disproportionate
 - (C) They are ignoring it
 - (D) They are permanently shutting down the models
5. What broader conflict exists between Anthropic and the Trump administration?
 - (A) Tax evasion
 - (B) Refusing to allow US military use for domestic surveillance and autonomous weapons
 - (C) Hiring Chinese nationals
 - (D) Copyright infringement
6. What risk do experts specifically warn about if such AI falls into malicious hands?
 - (A) Stock market crash
 - (B) Supercharged cyberattacks on banking systems
 - (C) Political propaganda campaigns
 - (D) Environmental damage

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Positive - National security first: Governments are responsible for protecting their citizens from catastrophic attacks. If a jailbreak could let an adversary turn an advanced model into a weapon that cripples banking systems or power grids, blocking access immediately -- even if based on verbal evidence -- is a justified precaution. Delaying could be far more dangerous.

2. Negative / Critical - Overreach and chilling effect: Critics say the order is a dramatic overreach that sets a bad precedent. Halting a widely used commercial product over an unconfirmed, narrow vulnerability risks stifling innovation and global collaboration. It also punishes researchers and companies that are vocal about AI safety, potentially discouraging transparency in the future.

3. Neutral / Analytical - The dual-use dilemma: This is not a new pattern; it mirrors the history of nuclear energy and encryption software. Almost any powerful technology can be used for good or evil. The core question is not whether to restrict it, but how: export controls were designed for physical goods and hardware, not for rapidly improving software that can be copied or accessed remotely. Current laws are struggling to catch up.

4. Forward-looking - Setting a global precedent: The outcome of this standoff could define AI governance for the next decade. If the US action stands, other nations may demand the same power to block foreign AI, leading to a fragmented internet where tools are walled off by country. Alternatively, the backlash could force a multilateral treaty -- something like a "Geneva Convention for AI" -- to balance safety with openness.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):
